HILCHOT PESAH - SHULHAN ARUKH

Hagalat Kelim: Kashering Utensils for Pesah — Libun, Hagalah & More

Hilchot Pesah: Siman 451

Recap of Previous Classes

Class	Simanim	Topics Covered
Class 1	429–432	30 days before Pesach; month of Nisan; Shabbat HaGadol; Bedikat Chametz timing; the bracha
Class 2	432–433	Why "al biur" not "al bedikat"; candle vs torch; where to check; high/low places; hole in walls; synagogues
Class 3	434–437	After Bedikah — bitul night and day; chametz timeline; appointing agents; missed bedikah; renting a house
Class 4	438–440	Mouse/child with chametz; kezayit threshold; kavua principle; non-Jew depositing chametz
Class 5	443–444:1	Chametz on Erev Pesach after six hours; calculating the times; smelling chametz; Erev Pesach on Shabbat (intro)
Class 6	444:2–5, 445	Erev Pesach on Shabbat (continued): bitul/bi'ur schedule; disposing on Shabbat; bi'ur chametz methods
Class 7	446–447:1–2	Finding chametz during Pesach; muktze on Yom Tov; kashrut principles; be-mashehu rule
Class 8	447:4, 5, 10	Chozer ve-ne'or (reawakening); practical implications for hechsherim; noten ta'am li-fgam on Pesach
Class 9	448	Chametz she'avar alav ha-Pesach; mechirat chametz — origins, kinyanim, and practical details; feeding animals
Class 10	**451:1–4, 6**	**Hag'alat Kelim Part 1: Torah sources, principles of kashering, libun vs hag'alah, rov tashmisho, earthenware, knives, bowls and cutlery**

Siman 451 – The Laws of Kashering Utensils (דיני הגעלת כלים)

Contains 27 Se'ifim — This class covers the foundational principles and Se'ifim 1–4, 6

Foundational Principles

Before diving into the Shulchan Aruch, several core principles must be understood. These underpin every halacha in this siman.

Principle 1: The Two Torah Sources for Hag'alat Kelim

Source 1 — Parshat Tzav (Vayikra 6:21) — The Korban Chatat

וכלי חרש אשר תבשל בו ישבר ואם בנחשת בשלה ומורק ושוטף במים

- **Earthenware** vessel used to cook the chatat offering → **must be broken** (cannot be kashered).
- **Copper/metal** vessel → can be **purged** (morak) and **rinsed** (shutaf) in water.

The Gemara (Avodah Zarah) derives: העידה תורה על כלי חרס שאין להם תקנה לצאת מידי דופיין — "The Torah testified that earthenware vessels have no remedy to remove their absorbed flavors."

Two lessons from this pasuk:

1. **Earthenware** that absorbed forbidden flavor through cooking **can never be purged** — it's too absorbent.
2. **Metal** utensils that absorbed forbidden flavor **can be purged** through water (hag'alah).

Source 2 — Parshat Matot (Bamidbar 31:22–23) — The War with Midian

After the war with Midian, Elazar HaKohen instructed Bnei Yisrael on how to kasher the captured utensils:

כל דבר אשר יבא באש תעבירו באש וטהר... וכל אשר לא יבא באש תעבירו במים

- If the utensil was **used with fire** (i.e., forbidden food was cooked in it with fire) → **pass it through fire** (libun).
- If it was **not used with fire** → **pass it through water** (hag'alah).

Rashi's principle: כבולעו כך פולטו — "The way it absorbed is the way it expels." This is the master rule of all kashering.

Note: The pasuk also requires tevilat kelim (immersion in a mikveh) for utensils acquired from a non-Jew — but that is a completely separate din from hag'alat kelim. You **cannot** kasher a utensil by taking it to the mikveh. These are two different processes.

Principle 2: Is There a Mitzvah to Kasher Utensils?

Opinion	Is Hag'alat Kelim a Mitzvah?	Reasoning
Tosafot	✅ Yes — just like tevilat kelim	Both are Torah-derived processes for making utensils usable
Rambam	❌ No — not listed in the 613 mitzvot	Hag'alah merely removes an obstacle (forbidden flavor). Tevilat kelim is a proactive transformation — changing the status of a utensil for Jewish use.

Practical consequence: No bracha is recited on hag'alat kelim — because even if it's a mitzvah, the consensus treats it as a preparatory process (hechsher mitzvah), not a standalone mitzvah.

Principle 3: Libun vs. Hag'alah — The Two Methods of Kashering

Feature	Libun (ליבון)	Hag'alah (הגעלה)
Method	Burn in intense fire until sparks fly / red hot	Immerse in boiling water
What it does	**Destroys** the absorbed flavor entirely	**Removes** the flavor from the walls into the water
Temperature	Extremely high (~250°C+, red hot)	Boiling (100°C, yad soledet bo ~45°C minimum)
When required	Utensil absorbed flavor **dry, with direct fire**	Utensil absorbed flavor **with water/liquid**
Immersion	N/A — fire-based	Can be done in halves (unlike tevilat kelim, which requires full immersion at once)

Libun Chamur vs. Libun Kal

Type	Definition	Who Holds
Libun Chamur (stringent)	Sparks fly from it / becomes red hot	Shulchan Aruch, Rambam — **one standard of libun**
Libun Kal (lenient)	Hot enough that straw placed on the outside would burn	Some Rishonim; Rama permits for doubtful cases

For Sephardim: Where libun is required, it means libun chamur — full intensity. There's no halfway.

For Ashkenazim (Rama): Libun chamur is the default, but libun kal can be used when there's doubt whether the utensil needs libun or merely hag'alah.

Why Doesn't the Flavor Reabsorb During Hag'alah?

Since hag'alah merely removes flavors into the water (unlike libun which destroys them), why don't the flavors go back into the pot?

Two answers in the Rishonim:

1. The boiling water that **causes the flavor to exit** cannot simultaneously **cause it to reabsorb** — the process only works in one direction at a time.
2. The water is assumed to be **60 times** the volume of the absorbed flavor — so the flavor becomes **nullified** (batel be-shishim) upon exiting the walls.

Practical consequence of this machloket: We advise **rinsing the utensil in cold water immediately after hag'alah** — to ensure the flavor doesn't reabsorb (satisfying the first reason).

Principle 4: Rov Tashmisho (רוב תשמישו) — Majority of Its Use

This is a critical principle that simplifies Pesach preparation enormously.

Rule: We follow the **majority** of how a utensil was used during the year — not the occasional exception.

Majority Use	Occasional Use	What's Required
With **water/liquid** (needs hag'alah)	Sometimes **dry on fire** (would need libun)	**Hag'alah** suffices
With **cold food**	Sometimes with **hot food**	**Washing** suffices — no kashering needed

Why so lenient? Because the entire requirement to kasher after 24 hours is only de-rabbanan (since after 24 hours, the flavor is noten ta'am li-fgam — degraded). Since it's a rabbinic decree, the Chachamim only applied it when the **majority** of use creates the concern.

Practical example: A pot used 100 times during the year — 97 times with cold chametz food, 3 times with hot chametz food. You only need to **wash it thoroughly** — no hag'alah needed, because rov tashmisho was cold.

Principle 5: Issura Bala vs. Hetera Bala (אסורא בלע / התירא בלע)

Core question: Was the absorbed food **forbidden** or **permissible** at the time of absorption?

The Gemara's undisputed rule: If the food was **permissible** when absorbed (hetera bala), then even dry absorption only needs **hag'alah** — not libun.

Example everyone agrees on: Sacrificial meat cooked on a spit — permissible when cooked, only becomes forbidden later (when the time limit passes). Even though it's dry/fire → hag'alah suffices because it was hetera bala.

The machloket: Is chametz hetera bala or issura bala?

Opinion	Chametz is...	Reasoning	Consequence
Rabbeinu Tam (Tosafot)	**Hetera bala** — absorbed permissibly	During the year when you cooked with chametz, it was completely permitted	You **never** need libun for Pesach. Hag'alah always suffices — even for dry/fire use.
The Rif	**Issura bala** — absorbed as if forbidden	Chametz is inherently something that becomes forbidden (unlike sacrifices, which are always permitted when fresh). Had it been Pesach, it would be forbidden.	Dry/fire use → needs **libun**

Shulchan Aruch: Follows the **Rif** — chametz is issura bala. Dry/fire use requires libun.

However — critical caveat (Mishnah Berurah 451:28): Rabbeinu Tam is still a significant opinion. Whenever there is **another reason to be lenient** (e.g., rov tashmisho, doubt about usage), we **combine** Rabbeinu Tam's opinion and treat chametz as hetera bala. This combination appears many times throughout this siman.

Principle 6: Kli Rishon, Irui Kli Rishon, and Kli Sheni

Level	Definition	Degree of Absorption
Kli Rishon (on fire)	Pot cooked directly on the stove/fire	Complete absorption through entire walls
Kli Rishon (off fire, still boiling)	Same pot, removed from fire but still roteach (boiling)	Same — complete absorption
Irui Kli Rishon	Pouring from a kli rishon onto/into another vessel	Absorbs **k'dei klipah** (a peel's depth) only
Kli Sheni	A vessel that received food/liquid from a kli rishon	On Shabbat: does not cook. On Pesach: slightly stricter (see Se'if 6)

The Shulchan Aruch — Se'if by Se'if

Se'if 1 — Earthenware (כלי חרס) and China

Shulchan Aruch: Earthenware pots used with chametz during the year:

1. **Clean them well** — ensure no visible chametz remains (mamashut / substance).
2. **Put them away** for after Pesach — store in a discreet place where you won't accidentally use them.
3. **After Pesach** — you may use them freely. The absorbed chametz in the walls is chametz she'avar alav ha-Pesach, but the Chachamim's penalty only applies to **tangible** chametz (mamash), not to **flavor absorbed in walls**.

Why is this not obvious? There was an opinion in the Gemara that the absorbed chametz flavor in the walls should also be treated as chametz she'avar alav ha-Pesach (and the pots could never be used again). **Shmuel** disagreed: the gezeirah only applies to tangible substance, not to absorbed flavor. We follow Shmuel.

Storage recommendations (from the Rishonim):

Source	Recommendation
Gemara / Shulchan Aruch	Put away in a discreet place you won't frequent
The Rosh	Put it somewhere you won't forget and use it accidentally
The Tur (son of the Rosh)	Lock it away and put the key somewhere separate
Nowadays	Sellotape / labels on the cabinets — serves as a reminder (equivalent of "locking")

Can earthenware be kashered at all?

Method	Does It Work?
Hag'alah (boiling water)	❌ No — earthenware is too absorbent
Pouring boiling water into it	❌ No — irui kli rishon still absorbs k'dei klipah
Libun (fire) in a regular oven	❌ No — insufficient; risk of not heating evenly
Reconstituting in a kiln (כבשן)	✅ Yes — putting it back in the kiln where new earthenware is fired essentially recreates the vessel

What About Kli Sheni?

- The Shulchan Aruch in Se'if 1 only mentions cooking and pouring (irui) as problematic — he does **not** mention kli sheni here.
- In Se'if 5 (and 6), he does say kli sheni should ideally be kashered.
- **The Poskim resolve this:** Since earthenware **cannot** be kashered anyway, and kli sheni is itself a chumra — you **can** use earthenware/china on Pesach that was only used as a kli sheni during the year (just wash it well).
- **Ashkenazim** disagree and would not permit this.
- **Even many Sephardim** would say don't do this in the first instance — but strictly speaking, there are grounds for leniency.

Practical example: China bowls used on the dinner table where food was poured into them (irui kli rishon → the bowl is kli sheni). Strictly speaking for Sephardim: wash well and usable on Pesach. In practice: most people have separate Pesach china.

Se'if 2 — [Specific utensil type — skipped as not practically relevant]

Se'if 3 — Knives (סכינים)

Shulchan Aruch: Knives — kasher with hag'alah in a kli rishon. That's sufficient.

But wait — shouldn't knives need libun? If you used a knife on a barbecue (dry, with direct fire), that should be issura bala requiring libun!

Why hag'alah suffices:

The Mishnah Berurah explains this is a **combination of two leniencies:**

1. **Rabbeinu Tam** — chametz is hetera bala, so you never need libun for Pesach anyway.
2. **Rov tashmisho** — knives are rarely used dry on the fire. Their majority use is with water, with food, on the table, cutting, etc.

These two reasons combined allow hag'alah for knives.

Exception: A knife used **exclusively** or **primarily** for barbecue (dry, on fire) — that specific knife **would need libun**.

What about knives used only with cold food?

- If a knife is only used to cut bread, cheese, vegetables — always cold — then me'ikar ha-din (strictly speaking) it doesn't need kashering at all. Just wash it thoroughly.
- **Rov tashmisho be-tzonen** (majority use is cold) = washing suffices.

Removing Rust Before Hag'alah

Shulchan Aruch (continuation): Before doing hag'alah on knives (or any utensil), you must:

- **Remove all rust** — the pasuk says אך את הזהב ("only the gold") — the word אך (ach) is a limitation: hag'alah must act on the **metal itself**, not on rust covering it.
- If there are **chips, grooves, or holes** where rust cannot be cleaned → hag'alah doesn't work there; those spots need **libun**.
- In practice: if you have very rusty utensils that can't be cleaned — you cannot kasher them.

Se'if 4 — Things Used on Naked Fire (Spits, Grills)

Shulchan Aruch: Utensils used directly on fire — such as **spits** (shefudim) and **grates/grills** (askalot) — require **libun**.

- This follows the **Rif** — chametz is issura bala.
- If it were like Rabbeinu Tam (hetera bala), libun would never be needed for Pesach.

Libun means: Sparks fly from it / it becomes **red hot** (~250°C+).

The Mishnah Berurah (451:28) adds the critical caveat:

> ומכל מקום אין ללמוד מדין זה למקומות אחרים — "Don't extrapolate from this to all other cases."

When there are **additional reasons to be lenient**, we combine Rabbeinu Tam's opinion and permit hag'alah instead of libun. The default follows the Rif (libun for dry/fire), but it's not applied rigidly in every scenario.

Se'if 6 — Bowls, Cutlery, and Rov Tashmisho in Practice

Shulchan Aruch: כל כלי הולכים בו אחר רוב תשמישו — We follow the majority of a utensil's use.

Example — Bowls (ke'arot):

- Bowls on the table: their majority use is receiving food **poured from** a kli rishon → that makes them **irui kli rishon** (the pouring is irui; the bowl itself becomes kli sheni).
- Even though sometimes the bowl is placed directly on the fire → since the majority is irui, kasher by irui (pouring boiling water over it). No need for full hag'alah in a kli rishon.

The Rama's Stringencies (Ashkenazi Practice)

The Rama disagrees with the Shulchan Aruch's leniency on rov tashmisho in three escalating ways:

Rama's Position	What It Means
Everything as kli rishon	Don't rely on rov tashmisho — kasher everything with full hag'alah in a kli rishon, even if majority use was irui or kli sheni
Even if "perhaps" used as kli rishon	Even spoons and cutlery — if there's any **possibility** it was once stuck into a pot on the fire → kasher as kli rishon
Even cold-use vessels	Drinking cups and vessels used primarily with cold — if there's any chance it was once used with hot chametz → kasher with hag'alah

This is why Ashkenazim kasher virtually everything — cutlery, cups, bowls — even when Sephardim would say it's unnecessary.

Practical Example: The Kiddush Cup

- Used throughout the year for **cold** grape juice/wine.
- Me'ikar ha-din (Sephardi): **no kashering needed** — rov tashmisho is cold. Just wash it.
- The Rama: perhaps during the year someone drank hot coffee in it, or it was washed in hot water with chametz dishes → kasher it, or use a new one for Pesach.
- **Strictly speaking:** There is absolutely no need for a separate Pesach Kiddush cup.

Using Cold Food in Non-Kosher/Chametz Utensils

Rama (from Hilchot Kashrut, applied here): Any utensil that needs kashering — you cannot use it even with cold food on a regular basis.

Why? The absorbed flavors can only be expelled with heat — cold food doesn't extract them. So technically, cold use is fine. But the Chachamim forbade it as a **regular practice** because you might forget and use it with hot food.

However — one-off use (be-derech arai) is permitted:

Scenario	Permitted?
Eating cold cereal and milk in a non-kosher hotel bowl (possibly used with bacon)	✅ Yes — one-off, cold, the bowl is clean
Keeping chametz plates in regular use throughout Pesach for cold food	❌ No — regular/fixed use
Emergency on Pesach: no clean dish available, using a clean chametz plate for cold food once	✅ Yes — one-off emergency

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Summary of Key Principles

Principle	Rule
Earthenware	Cannot be kashered (break it or put it away for after Pesach)
Metal	Can be kashered — libun (dry/fire) or hag'alah (liquid)
Ke-volo kach polto	The way it absorbed is the way it's expelled
Libun	Sparks / red hot (~250°C+). Destroys the absorbed flavor.
Hag'alah	Immersed in boiling water. Removes flavor into the water. Rinse immediately after.
Rov Tashmisho	Follow the majority use — not the occasional exception
Hetera Bala / Issura Bala	Rabbeinu Tam: chametz = hetera bala (never need libun). Rif/Shulchan Aruch: chametz = issura bala. But Rabbeinu Tam is combined with other leniencies when available.
Ben Yomo (24 hours)	After 24 hours, absorbed flavor is degraded (noten ta'am li-fgam). All kashering after 24 hours is de-rabbanan.
Cold use	Technically fine (no extraction), but forbidden as regular practice. One-off = permitted.
Kli Rishon → Irui → Kli Sheni	Decreasing levels of absorption and severity. Kasher at the level it absorbed.

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